SUMMARY

- Midwifery is the art and science of caring for woman undergoing normal pregnancy, labour and the period following child birth.
- Normal pregnancy involves a continuous process. It is divided into three trimesters. It starts from fertilization to delivery of the fetus.
- Physiological changes occur during pregnancy especially there is marked changes in genitourinary system. Pregnancy is diagnosed by first in urine testing of beta HCG and confirmed by ultasonogram. Expected date of delivery is calculated by last menstrual period.
- Antenatal care refers to the care given to an expectant mother from the time of conception to the beginning of labour. Importance of regular follow up should be insisted to the women. Advise them to take regular calcium, iron and folic acid.
- Identification of high risk pregnancy and provide appropriate treatment to reduce the maternal and fetal morbidity and mortality.
- Each visit should check blood pressure and weight in order to identity the early signs of pregnancy induced hypertension which is major cause of maternal death and fetal death.
- Labour is the process resulting from uterine contraction leading to expulsion of products of conception from the uterine cavity through vagina. Labour is diagnosed by dilatation of cervix and contraction of uterus.
- A serious of movements adapted by fetus in the birth passage during expulsion is called mechanism of normal labour. Mechanism of normal labour falls on: - (3 P's) power, passage, and passenger.

There are three stages of labor.

- First stage: First stage of labour is the interval between the onset of labour and full cervical dilatation. Duration is 6 – 12 hours.
- Second stage: It is the interval between full cervical dilatation and delivery of the fetus.
- Third stage: It is the interval between the delivery of the fetus and delivery of the plancenta, umbilical cord and fetal membranes and last 15 – 30 minutes.
- Puerperium is the period following childbirth during which the body tissues especially the pelvic organs, revert approximately to the pre-pregnant state both anatomically and physiologically. Post natal care which includes of rest, sleep, early ambulation, diet, hygiene, etc.
- First 24 hours is crucial for the newborn where most of the complication occur during that period. Feeding should be planned for every 2 – 4 hours intervals including demand of the baby
- Early initiation of breast feeding should be initiated within 1 hour of child birth. Educate the mother about the exclusive breast feeding for six month and continue for 2 years along with weaning food.
- Mother has to be instructed to follow contraceptive methods. There are two types of contraception temporary and permanent. Temporary methods divided into natural, hormonal, intrauterine devices and barrier methods. Tubectomy and vasectomy are the permanent methods.

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